

Being Aware: Understanding Ovarian Cancer

Introduction

Ovarian cancer is one of the most serious threats to women's health, yet it often goes unnoticed until it's in an advanced stage. This silent disease is the eighth most common cancer among women worldwide, with nearly 314,000 new cases diagnosed each year¹.

In India, ovarian cancer is the third most common cancer among women, with an incidence rate of around 10 per 100,000 women, and the mortality rate is particularly concerning, with an estimated 35,779 deaths in 2020⁶.

The increasing burden of ovarian cancer in India is attributed to lifestyle changes, increasing life expectancy, and a lack of widespread screening programs⁷. The late-stage diagnosis remains a significant issue in India, where cultural stigma and limited access to healthcare services further exacerbate the challenge.

The Burden of Ovarian Cancer

Ovarian cancer primarily affects women aged 50 and older, although it can occur at any age. The disease is often called a "silent killer" because its symptoms are vague and easily mistaken for less serious conditions like gastrointestinal issues. This often leads to delayed diagnoses, with more than 70% of cases being diagnosed at an advanced stage when the cancer has already spread beyond the ovaries¹. Unfortunately, the five-year survival rate for advanced ovarian cancer is less than 30%, compared to over 90% if caught early⁵.

Risk Factors

1. Family history is one of the most significant risk factors; women with close relatives who have had ovarian cancer, breast cancer, or colorectal cancer are at higher risk. This is especially true for women who carry inherited mutations in the BRCA1 and BRCA2 genes, which are also linked to breast cancer³.
2. Age is another critical factor, with most cases occurring in women over 50¹.
3. Women who have never been pregnant or those with a history of endometriosis are at higher risk⁴.
4. Early onset of menstruation and late menopause can contribute to this increased risk¹.
5. Hormone replacement therapy, particularly estrogen-only therapy, has also been associated with an increased risk of ovarian cancer¹.
6. Lifestyle factors can play a role as well. Obesity is linked to a higher risk, and some studies suggest that diets high

in fat may contribute to the disease¹.

On the other hand, the use of oral contraceptives, tubal ligation, and breastfeeding have been shown to reduce the risk of ovarian cancer¹.

Symptoms and Diagnosis

One of the challenges of ovarian cancer is that its symptoms are non-specific and often attributed to benign conditions. Common symptoms include bloating, pelvic or abdominal pain, difficulty eating or feeling full quickly, and urinary symptoms such as urgency or frequency⁴. These symptoms are persistent and represent a change from normal for the individual. If they occur almost daily for more than a few weeks, it is essential to consult a doctor⁵.

Diagnosis usually begins with a pelvic examination, where a doctor feels for any masses or irregularities⁵. If ovarian cancer is suspected, the next step often involves imaging tests like transvaginal ultrasound or CT scans to get a clearer view of the ovaries⁵. Blood tests, particularly the CA-125 blood test, can also be used to detect a protein that is often higher in women with ovarian cancer, though it is not used alone for diagnosis⁵.

A definitive diagnosis of ovarian cancer is made through surgery, where a sample of tissue is removed and examined under a microscope⁵. This procedure, often accompanied by the removal of the affected ovary or ovaries, helps to determine the stage and type of cancer, guiding further treatment decisions⁵.

Prognosis and Survival Rates

The prognosis for ovarian cancer varies significantly depending on the stage at which it is diagnosed. Early-stage cancers generally have a much better survival rate compared to those diagnosed at an advanced stage¹. The overall 5-year survival rate for ovarian cancer is approximately 47%, but this rate improves with early detection and effective treatment⁵.

When to See a Doctor

Given the subtlety of ovarian cancer symptoms, it is crucial to pay attention to your body and consult a healthcare provider if you notice any persistent changes⁴. Women with a family history of ovarian or breast cancer should discuss their risk with their doctor, as they may benefit from genetic counseling or more frequent screenings³.

Women should also be aware of their



bodies and advocate for themselves in healthcare settings. Early detection is key to increasing the chances of survival, so it's important to act quickly if you suspect something is wrong.

Conclusion

Ovarian cancer is a formidable opponent, but increased awareness and early detection can significantly improve outcomes. By understanding the risks, recognizing the symptoms, and knowing when to seek medical advice, women can take proactive steps to protect their health. Regular check-ups and open communication with healthcare providers are essential in the fight against this disease.

References

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